

The Complete Contents Claim Workbook

Room-by-Room Methodology for Personal Property Claims

By Leland Coontz
California Licensed Public Adjuster

insuranceclaimsinfo.com

Important Disclaimer

This guide is provided for educational and informational purposes only. It is not legal advice. The information contained in this guide is based on the author's professional experience as a California Licensed Public Adjuster and may not apply to your specific situation or state.

Insurance policies, state regulations, and case law vary significantly from state to state and change over time. Always consult with a licensed public adjuster or attorney in your state before making decisions about your insurance claim.

The examples and scenarios described in this guide are drawn from real-world experience but have been generalized for educational purposes. Any resemblance to specific claims or individuals is coincidental unless otherwise noted.

No part of this guide may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form without the prior written permission of the author.

© 2026 Leland Coontz. All Rights Reserved.

insuranceclaimsinfo.com

CHAPTER 1

How Contents Claims Work

Coverage C — Personal Property — is the part of your homeowner's policy that covers your belongings. Everything inside your home that is not part of the structure itself falls under this coverage: furniture, clothing, electronics, appliances, kitchenware, books, artwork, tools, sporting equipment, toys, and thousands of other items. Your Coverage C limit is typically 50-75% of your Coverage A (dwelling) limit, though this varies by policy.

Contents claims are handled differently from structural claims in several important ways. First, the burden of proof is on you — the policyholder — to document what you owned and what it was worth. The carrier will not inventory your home for you. Second, contents are subject to depreciation, which means the carrier will first pay you the actual cash value (ACV) of your items and withhold a depreciation holdback that you can recover later when you actually replace the items.

Third, contents claims have special limits — also called sublimits — for certain categories of items. For example, your policy may limit coverage for jewelry to \$2,500, firearms to \$2,500, silverware to \$2,500, and so on, unless you have purchased a scheduled endorsement for higher limits. Check your policy declarations page for these sublimits.

Check Your Sublimits

Review your policy's special limits NOW — before a loss occurs if possible. If your jewelry, firearms, collectibles, or other high-value items exceed the sublimits, you need a scheduled endorsement to get full coverage.

CHAPTER 2

ACV vs. RCV: How to Get Full Replacement

Understanding the difference between Actual Cash Value (ACV) and Replacement Cost Value (RCV) is fundamental to maximizing your contents claim recovery. Most modern homeowner's policies provide replacement cost coverage for contents, which means you are entitled to the full cost of replacing your items with new items of like kind and quality. But the payment comes in two stages.

Stage 1: The ACV Payment

When you submit your contents inventory, the carrier calculates the replacement cost of each item and then subtracts depreciation based on the item's age and condition. The result is the ACV — and that is what you are paid initially. For example, if a sofa costs \$2,000 to replace and is 5 years old with a 15-year useful life, the carrier might depreciate it by 33%, paying you \$1,340 as the ACV.

Stage 2: The Recoverable Depreciation Payment

Once you actually replace the item — meaning you buy a new sofa of comparable kind and quality — you can submit the receipt to the carrier and recover the depreciation holdback. In the example above, you would recover the remaining \$660. Your total recovery is the full replacement cost.

SB 49 Game Changer

After a declared disaster in California, SB 49 changed the rules: carriers must allow policyholders to collect full replacement cost for contents **WITHOUT** requiring proof of actual replacement. This means you get the full RCV for contents upfront without having to buy replacement items first. This applies only after a declared disaster.

Strategies for Maximizing Recovery

- Always claim replacement cost, not what you originally paid — prices go up over time
- Use current retail pricing from major retailers as your replacement cost source
- Challenge excessive depreciation — a well-maintained item depreciates less than a neglected one
- Remember that labor cannot be depreciated in California — only materials
- Replace items within your policy's time limit (usually 180 days to 2 years after ACV payment)
- You can replace with any item of like kind and quality — it does not have to be the same brand
- Keep all replacement receipts organized for recoverable depreciation claims

CHAPTER 3

Room-by-Room Inventory Methodology

This is the heart of this workbook. A thorough room-by-room inventory is the difference between a contents claim that recovers 40% of your losses and one that recovers 90% or more. The methodology is straightforward, but it requires patience and persistence.

General Approach

1. Start with one room at a time — do not try to inventory your entire home in one session
2. Work around the room clockwise, wall by wall, starting at the door
3. For each wall, list what was against it, on it, or near it
4. Open every drawer, cabinet, and closet in your mind — list everything inside
5. Look up at the ceiling (light fixtures, fans, smoke detectors) and down at the floor (rugs, mats)
6. Use old photographs, videos, and shopping records to trigger your memory
7. Take breaks — this process is emotionally exhausting and memory works better in short sessions
8. Come back to each room multiple times over several weeks — you will remember more each time

Living Room / Family Room

- Sofas, loveseats, chairs, recliners — note material, brand, and size
- Coffee tables, end tables, sofa tables, console tables
- Entertainment center, TV stand, or media furniture
- Television(s) — note size, brand, and whether they were smart TVs
- Sound system, speakers, soundbar, subwoofer

- Streaming devices (Roku, Apple TV, Fire Stick)
- Gaming consoles and games (PS5, Xbox, Nintendo Switch)
- Lamps — table lamps, floor lamps, accent lighting
- Area rugs and decorative mats
- Artwork, framed photographs, wall decorations
- Books, magazines, and bookshelf contents
- Throw pillows, blankets, and decorative items
- Curtains, drapes, and window treatments
- Plants and planters
- Remote controls, batteries, chargers

Kitchen

- Small appliances: toaster, blender, food processor, coffee maker, mixer, etc.
- Pots and pans — list each piece, including lids
- Baking sheets, muffin tins, cake pans, cooling racks
- Dishes and dinnerware — count full sets, note pattern and manufacturer
- Glasses and stemware — everyday and special occasion
- Flatware/silverware — everyday and formal sets
- Knives — knife block or individual quality knives
- Cutting boards
- Utensils — spatulas, whisks, tongs, ladles, serving spoons (count them all)
- Storage containers (Tupperware, glass containers)
- Spice collection — check current prices, spices are expensive
- Cookbooks
- Kitchen towels, pot holders, oven mitts
- Under-sink cleaning supplies and chemicals
- Pantry contents — food items are covered if they were contaminated or destroyed

Master Bedroom

- Bed frame, headboard, footboard — note size (king, queen, etc.)
- Mattress and box spring — note brand and quality level
- Bedding: sheets, pillowcases, comforter, duvet, bed skirt, decorative pillows
- Nightstands and bedside lamps
- Dresser and/or chest of drawers
- Clothing — this is a major category; go through by type (see below)
- Shoes — count every pair including athletic, casual, dress, boots, sandals
- Jewelry — note high-value items separately for sublimit purposes
- Watches
- Closet organizers, hangers, storage boxes
- Alarm clock, phone charger, personal electronics

Clothing Inventory Tips

Clothing is one of the most frequently undervalued categories in contents claims. People forget how much clothing they actually own. Work through it systematically by category: shirts, pants, shorts, dresses, skirts, suits, jackets, coats, underwear, socks, athletic wear, sleepwear, and seasonal items. For each category, count the quantity and estimate the average replacement cost per item.

Clothing Adds Up Fast

The average American adult owns approximately 100 items of clothing. At an average replacement cost of \$30 per item, that is \$3,000 per person in clothing alone. Many families significantly undercount their clothing inventory.

CHAPTER 4

Cleaning vs. Replacement Determination

Not every item of personal property that is damaged in a loss needs to be replaced. Some items can be professionally cleaned and restored. The question of whether an item should be cleaned or replaced is a significant source of dispute between policyholders and carriers.

Carriers have a financial incentive to clean rather than replace — cleaning is almost always cheaper. But cleaning is only appropriate when it can restore the item to its pre-loss condition. If professional cleaning cannot fully remove smoke odor from a sofa, the sofa needs to be replaced. If cleaning cannot remove staining from clothing, the clothing needs to be replaced.

General Guidelines

- Hard, non-porous surfaces (glass, metal, sealed wood) can often be cleaned successfully
- Soft, porous items (upholstery, mattresses, pillows, stuffed animals) may retain odor even after cleaning
- Electronics may be damaged internally even if they appear clean externally — circuitry is vulnerable
- Food items exposed to smoke or contamination should always be replaced, never cleaned
- Baby items, children's toys, and items used near the face/mouth should be replaced for safety reasons
- Clothing depends on the fabric and the type of contamination — some can be cleaned, some cannot
- Documents, books, and paper items are extremely difficult to fully decontaminate from smoke

Your Right to Replacement

You are not required to accept cleaned items that still smell, are stained, or are otherwise not restored to pre-loss condition. If the cleaning company returns your items and they are not right, document the deficiency and demand replacement.

When the carrier proposes cleaning, ask for specifics: what cleaning method will be used? What is the success rate for that method on that type of item? Will the carrier guarantee the cleaning restores the item to pre-loss condition? If the cleaning fails, will the carrier then pay for replacement? Get these answers in writing before you agree to cleaning.

CHAPTER 5

Electronics and Specialty Items

Electronics deserve special attention in contents claims because they are high-value, technology changes rapidly, and damage from smoke, water, or power surges is often invisible. A television that appears to work after a fire may fail weeks later due to corrosion on internal circuitry caused by smoke exposure.

Common Electronics to Inventory

- Televisions — each one, with size and brand
- Computers — desktops, laptops, tablets
- Smartphones and cell phones
- Printers, scanners, and peripherals
- Gaming consoles and controllers
- Smart home devices (Alexa, Google Home, smart thermostats, cameras)
- Routers, modems, and networking equipment
- External hard drives, USB drives, and storage devices
- Headphones and earbuds
- Camera equipment — bodies, lenses, accessories
- Musical instruments and amplifiers
- Power tools (these are often overlooked — they are expensive)

Specialty Items

Specialty items include collections, artwork, antiques, musical instruments, wine, firearms, and other items that may have special value or require specialized valuation. These items often bump up against policy sublimits and may require a scheduled endorsement for full coverage.

Current Replacement Cost

For high-value electronics and specialty items, always provide the replacement cost with a current equivalent model — not the original purchase price. Technology depreciates in value but the replacement cost for a comparable current model is what matters.

- Art and collectibles — get independent appraisals for high-value items
- Wine collections — document vintage, quantity, and current market value per bottle
- Firearms — check current retail prices, not what you paid years ago
- Musical instruments — professional-grade instruments can be extremely valuable
- Sporting equipment — golf clubs, bikes, ski equipment, fishing gear all add up
- Tools and workshop equipment — go shelf by shelf through your workshop or garage

CHAPTER 6

Pack-Out and Storage Documentation

When your home is damaged but not destroyed, the carrier will often arrange for a 'pack-out' — a process where a contents restoration company comes to your home, inventories your belongings, packs them into boxes, and transports them to a storage facility for cleaning, restoration, or safekeeping during repairs.

The pack-out process creates several documentation challenges. Items can be damaged during packing or transport. Items can be lost in storage. Items can be returned in worse condition than when they left. And the carrier's preferred pack-out company may not properly document what they took or the condition it was in when they took it.

Protecting Yourself During Pack-Out

1. Be present during the entire pack-out process — or have a trusted representative present
2. Take photographs of every room before the pack-out begins
3. Photograph items as they are packed — document the condition before packing
4. Get a complete inventory list from the pack-out company, with room assignments for each box
5. Note the condition of items on the inventory list — add your own notes if the company's notes are vague
6. Record the serial numbers and model numbers of electronics before they are packed
7. Mark or tag high-value items for special handling
8. Get the storage facility address and confirm you will have access to your belongings if needed

Review the Pack-Out Inventory

The pack-out company's inventory is often used as the basis for the contents claim. If their

inventory is incomplete or inaccurate, it will hurt your claim. Review their inventory carefully and supplement it with your own documentation.

When items are returned after cleaning, inspect every single item. Compare returned items to the pack-out inventory. Note any items that are missing, damaged, or not properly cleaned. Document deficiencies in writing immediately and notify the carrier. You are entitled to replacement for any items that were lost or damaged during the pack-out and storage process.

CHAPTER 7

Presenting Your Inventory to the Insurance Company

How you present your contents inventory to the carrier matters almost as much as what is on it. A well-organized, clearly formatted inventory with supporting documentation will be processed faster and with fewer disputes than a handwritten list on notebook paper.

Inventory Format

Use a spreadsheet with the following columns for each item: Room | Item Description | Quantity | Age (Years) | Condition (Excellent/Good/Fair/Poor) | Original Purchase Price (if known) | Replacement Cost | Source for Replacement Cost (retailer name and URL) | Depreciation (carrier will calculate, but you can note your position).

Supporting Documentation

- Photographs showing items in your home (pre-loss if available)
- Purchase receipts, credit card statements, or bank records for major items
- Printouts showing current retail prices for replacement items
- Appraisals for high-value items (jewelry, art, antiques)
- Product registration records or warranty documentation
- Screenshots from online retailer websites showing current pricing

Submission Best Practices

1. Submit the inventory electronically (email or carrier's portal) and by mail for a paper trail
2. Include a cover letter summarizing the total claim amount and the number of items

3. Organize the inventory by room for easy review
4. Flag high-value items that approach or exceed sublimits
5. Note any items for which you are requesting an exception to cleaning (i.e., replacement instead)
6. Keep a complete copy of everything you submit — never send your only copy of anything

Presentation Matters

Make the adjuster's job easy. A clean, well-organized inventory with supporting documentation gets processed faster and with less pushback. A messy, incomplete inventory invites scrutiny and delays.

CHAPTER 8

Common Contents Claim Mistakes

Having handled thousands of contents claims, I see the same mistakes over and over. Each one costs policyholders money — sometimes a lot of money. Avoid these common pitfalls.

Mistake 1: Underestimating What You Owned

This is the most common and most costly mistake. People think they do not own that much stuff — until they try to list everything. The average American household contains an astonishing number of items. Go room by room, drawer by drawer, shelf by shelf. You will be surprised at how much you forgot.

Mistake 2: Using Purchase Price Instead of Replacement Cost

Your coverage is for replacement cost — what it costs to buy a comparable item today — not what you paid five or ten years ago. Prices go up. The sofa you bought for \$800 in 2015 costs \$1,200 to replace today. Always use current retail pricing.

Mistake 3: Not Claiming Partially Damaged Items

If an item is damaged but not destroyed, it is still a covered loss. A smoke-damaged suit that needs professional cleaning is a claim. A water-stained dining table that needs refinishing is a claim. You do not have to lose an item completely for it to be covered.

Mistake 4: Missing the Replacement Deadline

Most policies require you to actually replace items within a specified time period (often 180 days to 2 years) after receiving the ACV payment in order to collect the recoverable depreciation. If you miss this deadline, you lose the depreciation holdback forever.

Calendar this deadline and prioritize replacing high-value items first.

Mistake 5: Accepting the Carrier's Cleaning Determination Without Challenge

As discussed in Chapter 4, carriers prefer cleaning to replacement because it is cheaper. If the cleaning does not restore the item to pre-loss condition, push back. Document the failure and demand replacement.

The Cost of Mistakes

The cumulative effect of these mistakes can easily be \$20,000 to \$50,000 or more on a large contents claim. Take your time, be thorough, and do not let the carrier rush you into settling for less than you are owed.

CHAPTER 9**SB 49 and Disaster Contents Rules**

Senate Bill 49, signed into law in California, changed the game for contents claims after declared disasters. Before SB 49, policyholders had to physically replace each item and submit a receipt before they could collect the recoverable depreciation — the difference between ACV and full replacement cost. This created an absurd burden: families who had just lost everything were expected to go shopping for thousands of items and save every receipt, all within a tight deadline, just to collect insurance benefits they had already paid for.

SB 49 eliminated this requirement for claims arising from declared disasters. After a declared disaster, your carrier must pay the full replacement cost of your contents without requiring proof that you actually replaced the items. You still need to document what you owned and its replacement cost, but you do not need to produce purchase receipts for replacement items.

When SB 49 Applies

SB 49 applies only to losses that arise from a declared disaster — a governor-declared state of emergency. It does not apply to ordinary fire losses, water damage, or other non-disaster claims. For non-disaster claims, the traditional two-step ACV-then-RCV process still applies.

Key Provisions of SB 49

- Carriers must pay full replacement cost for contents without requiring proof of actual replacement
- Policyholders still must document what they owned and its replacement cost
- The law applies to policies issued or renewed after its effective date for declared disaster losses
- Carriers cannot use the old two-step process to delay full payment on disaster contents claims
- The law does not change sublimits or other policy provisions — it only affects the

replacement requirement

If your loss is from a declared disaster and your carrier is insisting you must replace items before collecting the full replacement cost, cite SB 49 (Insurance Code Section 2051.5) and demand full payment. If the carrier refuses, file a complaint with the California Department of Insurance and consult with an attorney about bad faith.

Practical Tips Under SB 49

1. Confirm your loss qualifies as a declared disaster — check the Governor's executive orders
2. Submit your contents inventory with current replacement pricing from major retailers
3. Cite Insurance Code Section 2051.5 in your cover letter when demanding full replacement cost
4. If the carrier issues only an ACV payment, respond in writing demanding the recoverable depreciation
5. Document the carrier's refusal to comply with SB 49 — this is a regulatory violation and potential bad faith
6. File a CDI complaint if the carrier does not comply within 30 days of your written demand

CHAPTER 10**The Garage, Attic, and Outdoor Areas**

These areas are the most commonly forgotten in contents claims, and they contain some of the most expensive items you own. Think about it — your garage might hold \$5,000 to \$20,000 in tools alone, plus sporting equipment, holiday decorations, automotive supplies, and stored household goods. The attic may contain seasonal items, family keepsakes, and extra furniture. Your outdoor areas include patio furniture, barbecue grills, garden tools, and landscaping equipment.

Garage Inventory

- Power tools — drill, circular saw, jigsaw, sander, reciprocating saw, table saw, miter saw
- Hand tools — hammers, screwdrivers, wrenches, pliers, socket sets, levels, tape measures
- Tool storage — toolbox, tool chest, workbench, pegboard organizer, wall-mounted storage
- Automotive supplies — jack, jack stands, jumper cables, oil, filters, cleaning supplies
- Lawn and garden — mower, edger, blower, trimmer, rake, shovel, hose, sprinklers, pots
- Sporting equipment — bicycles, golf clubs, ski equipment, camping gear, fishing gear, surfboards
- Holiday decorations — Christmas, Halloween, Easter, and seasonal items (these add up fast)
- Storage bins and containers — and their contents (do not forget what is inside them)
- Ladders — extension ladder, step ladder, folding ladder
- Workbench items — nuts, bolts, screws, nails, adhesives, paint supplies, sandpaper

Attic and Storage Areas

- Seasonal clothing stored in bins or garment bags
- Family photos and photo albums (these may have sentimental value beyond replacement cost)
- Baby items — cribs, strollers, car seats, clothing (even if your children have outgrown them)
- Extra furniture — pieces not currently in use but in storage
- Old electronics — computers, phones, cameras that still have value
- Books and media — boxes of books, DVDs, CDs, vinyl records
- Luggage and travel bags
- Craft and hobby supplies — sewing machines, fabric, art supplies, musical instruments

Outdoor and Patio

- Patio furniture — table, chairs, umbrella, cushions, covers
- Barbecue grill and accessories — propane tank, tools, cover, smoker
- Outdoor lighting — string lights, solar lights, path lights
- Planters, pots, and garden ornaments
- Outdoor toys and play equipment — swing sets, trampolines, sports nets
- Pool or spa supplies — if applicable, chemicals, vacuum, covers, floats
- Firewood and fire pit accessories

Garages Are Goldmines

Garage contents alone can easily total \$10,000 to \$30,000 in a typical home. Do not skip these areas. Walk through them mentally just as carefully as you walk through the interior of your home.

CHAPTER 11

Challenging the Carrier's Contents Valuation

After you submit your contents inventory, the carrier will review it, assign values, and issue a payment. In my experience, the carrier's initial valuation is almost always lower than it should be. They use lower-quality replacement items, apply excessive depreciation, and sometimes simply reduce quantities without explanation.

Common Carrier Valuation Tricks

- Substituting lower-quality replacement items — replacing your premium cookware with budget brands
- Using wholesale or clearance pricing instead of standard retail pricing
- Depreciating items beyond their actual condition — a well-maintained item depreciates less
- Grouping items into categories and applying a blanket value instead of pricing each item individually
- Ignoring specialty or high-value items that they do not want to research
- Claiming items are 'used' and applying garage-sale pricing instead of replacement cost
- Applying a 'reasonableness' reduction to the total without item-by-item justification

When you receive the carrier's valuation, review it line by line. For every item where the carrier's value differs from yours, ask for a written explanation. If the carrier used a lower-quality replacement item, provide evidence of the actual quality you owned — brand name, product line, purchase receipt, or photograph. If the carrier over-depreciated, explain the actual condition of the item and provide evidence of its maintenance history if available.

Like Kind and Quality

The replacement cost is the cost to buy a new item of like kind and quality — not the cheapest possible substitute. If you owned a KitchenAid stand mixer, the carrier cannot value it at the price of a generic mixer from a discount store. Like kind and quality means comparable brand, features, and quality level.

CHAPTER 12

Sample Contents Inventory Cover Letter

[Date]

[Insurance Company Name]

[Claims Department Address]

Re: Insured: [Your Name]

Policy Number: [Policy Number]

Claim Number: [Claim Number]

Date of Loss: [Date of Loss]

PERSONAL PROPERTY CONTENTS INVENTORY — COVERAGE C CLAIM

Dear [Adjuster Name]:

Please find enclosed my personal property inventory for the above-referenced claim. This inventory covers [number] items across [number] rooms and areas, with a total claimed replacement cost value of \$[amount].

The inventory is organized room by room and includes the following information for each item: description, quantity, age, condition at the time of loss, and current replacement cost with a source citation (retailer name and price as of the date of this submission).

I have also enclosed supporting documentation including:

- Pre-loss photographs showing items in my home
- Purchase receipts and credit card statements for major items
- Current retail pricing printouts from major retailers

Please note that this inventory may be supplemented as I continue to recall additional items. Per California law, my right to supplement this inventory does not expire with this initial submission.

I request that your valuation be provided in writing on a line-by-line basis, showing the replacement item selected, the replacement cost, and the depreciation applied for each item. This will allow me to review your valuation and identify any items where additional

documentation may be needed.

Please process this claim and issue payment within 30 days as required by 10 CCR 2695.7(h).

Sincerely,
[Your Name]

Demand Line-by-Line

Always request the carrier's line-by-line valuation in writing. This forces the carrier to justify every number and makes it easy to identify and challenge items where they have undervalued your property.

CHAPTER 13

Bathroom and Laundry Room Inventory

Bathrooms and laundry rooms are often underinventoried because we take for granted the dozens of small items they contain. But these items add up quickly. A well-stocked master bathroom can easily contain \$2,000 to \$5,000 in contents between toiletries, towels, personal care appliances, medications, and decorative items.

Master Bathroom

- Towels — bath towels, hand towels, washcloths (count each set)
- Bath mat and rug
- Shower curtain, liner, and rings (or glass enclosure accessories)
- Toiletries — shampoo, conditioner, body wash, soap, face wash, lotion
- Cosmetics and makeup — foundation, concealer, eye products, lip products, brushes
- Fragrances and cologne — high-end fragrances can be very expensive
- Hair appliances — blow dryer, flat iron, curling iron, clippers
- Electric toothbrush, water flosser, oral care products
- Medications — both prescription and over-the-counter (list each one)
- First aid supplies — bandages, antibiotic ointment, thermometer, etc.
- Scale, tissue box holder, wastebasket, organizers
- Decorative items — candles, art, plants, mirrors

Guest Bathroom

- Towels, bath mat, shower curtain (just as fully stocked as the master, often forgotten)
- Guest toiletries and supplies

- Decorative items specific to this bathroom

Laundry Room

- Laundry detergent, fabric softener, stain remover, bleach
- Iron and ironing board
- Drying rack
- Laundry baskets and hampers
- Cleaning supplies stored here — mop, broom, vacuum, Swiffer, cleaning chemicals
- Storage items — extra paper towels, toilet paper, trash bags
- Sewing kit and mending supplies

CHAPTER 14**Home Office and Children's Rooms**

Home Office

With the rise of remote work, home offices have become significant concentrations of value. A well-equipped home office can easily contain \$5,000 to \$15,000 in contents between computers, monitors, printers, furniture, and supplies.

- Desk and office chair
- Computer — desktop or laptop, with specifications noted (RAM, storage, processor)
- Monitor(s) — size and brand for each
- Keyboard, mouse, mousepad, webcam, microphone
- Printer, scanner, copier — including ink or toner supplies
- External hard drives, USB drives, docking station
- Desk lamp and any other lighting
- Office supplies — paper, pens, staplers, tape, files, folders, binders
- Bookshelf contents — reference books, manuals, binders
- Filing cabinet and contents (the cabinet itself has value)
- Decorative items — art, plants, awards, diplomas, photo frames
- Surge protector, UPS battery backup, power strips, cable management

Children's Bedrooms

Children's rooms are inventory-dense. Between clothing, toys, books, electronics, and school supplies, a child's room can easily contain \$3,000 to \$8,000 or more in contents. Teenagers' rooms often contain even more, especially if they have gaming systems, musical instruments, or hobby equipment.

- Bed, mattress, and all bedding (sheets, comforter, pillows, decorative pillows)
- Dresser and/or chest of drawers
- Desk and chair for homework
- Clothing — children grow fast; they often have more clothes than adults
- Shoes — athletic, casual, dress, seasonal
- Toys — action figures, dolls, building sets, board games, puzzles, stuffed animals
- Books — picture books, chapter books, textbooks, reference books
- Electronics — tablet, gaming console, games, headphones, phone
- Sports equipment — cleats, shin guards, bats, balls, helmets, gear bags
- Musical instruments — if applicable
- School supplies — backpack, notebooks, calculators, art supplies
- Decorative items — posters, wall art, lamps, clocks, piggy banks

Children Own More Than You Think

Do not underestimate children's contents. Parents often say 'they did not have much' but when you go drawer by drawer and shelf by shelf, the total is almost always higher than expected. Lego sets alone can be worth hundreds or thousands of dollars per collection.

CHAPTER 15

Contents Claim Quick Reference and Summary

Use this final chapter as your at-a-glance reference for managing your contents claim from start to finish.

Contents Claim Process Summary

1. Review your policy — know your Coverage C limit, sublimits, and whether you have RCV or ACV coverage
2. Begin your inventory immediately — memory fades fast; start while details are fresh
3. Use the room-by-room methodology — work systematically to avoid missing items
4. Gather supporting documentation — photos, receipts, purchase histories, bank statements
5. Price every item at current replacement cost — use major retailer websites for pricing sources
6. Submit the inventory with a professional cover letter and supporting documentation
7. Review the carrier's valuation line by line — challenge every item where they undervalued
8. Supplement the inventory as you remember additional items — do not assume the window has closed
9. Track the replacement deadline — replace high-value items first to collect recoverable depreciation
10. After a declared disaster, cite SB 49 for full replacement cost without proof of actual replacement

Key Dollar Amounts to Remember

- Average US household contents value: \$100,000 to \$200,000 (many people underestimate by 50% or more)
- Average clothing per adult: \$3,000 to \$5,000 replacement cost
- Average kitchen contents: \$5,000 to \$15,000 replacement cost
- Average garage contents: \$5,000 to \$20,000 replacement cost
- Average electronics per household: \$5,000 to \$15,000 replacement cost
- Average master bedroom including closet: \$8,000 to \$20,000 replacement cost

You Own More Than You Think

The total replacement cost of your household contents is almost certainly higher than you think. Most families estimate their contents at \$50,000 to \$75,000 when the actual replacement cost is \$150,000 to \$250,000. Take your time, be thorough, and do not leave money on the table.

Need Help With Your Claim?

If you're dealing with an insurance company that isn't treating you fairly, you don't have to fight alone. A licensed public adjuster works for you — not the insurance company — to make sure you receive every dollar you're entitled to under your policy.

Visit: insuranceclaimsinfo.com

Free resources, guides, and expert help for policyholders

Leland Coontz

California Licensed Public Adjuster